

Chapter 2

HISTORICAL PERSPECTIVES ON AMAZONIAN DARK EARTHS

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1. INTRODUCTION

When Europeans entered Amazônia in the middle of the sixteenth century they found it densely inhabited from the Japurá River eastward to the mouth of the Amazon (Fig. 1). At the Rio Tapajós, the land was thickly covered with dwellings and there were reported to be more than five thousand warriors (Oviedo, 1934). A settlement between the Negro and Purús rivers was more than two and a half leagues long with more than 500 multi-family dwellings (Carvajal, 1934; Oviedo, 1934), perhaps 10,000 inhabitants. A century later, a town in the adjacent province was more than a league and a half in length, with four, five, or more families living in a single house (Acuña, 1942; Porro, 1996). The size of archaeological sites at Tapajós, Manacapuru, and elsewhere supports the eyewitness testimony that contact period settlements included many large towns. If population density promotes agricultural intensification, the situation was certainly ripe on the lower Amazon. Elsewhere in the world irrigation and terracing were often the means by which ever increasing numbers of people were supported in a circumscribed space. In the Amazon it was frequently dark earth (Amazonian Dark Earth ADE) technology.

West of the Japurá River, densely inhabited regions alternated with great stretches of unoccupied territory not only of the Solimões itself, but also on the lower Napo, Ucayali, Huallaga, and Marañon rivers. Approximately fifty leagues (210 km) separated one province from the next. Descending the Huallaga River in 1560, Pedro de Orsúa passed only one settlement before he reached the Napo River, a distance of more than three hundred kilometers. There were no settlements at all reported on the Marañon or the upper Solimões between the Huallaga and Napo rivers (Myers, 1992a; Porro, 1993, 1996).

We know much less about settlement patterns and population densities away from the major rivers. Even the Japurá, Madeira, and Negro rivers were never seen

